

Going against the Flow

In chapter 2, I talked about Michael Phelps and how his body was practically designed for swimming. Way down at the opposite end of the “made for swimming” spectrum is Chris Hogan. Phelps is built like a torpedo; I’m built like a tank—and tanks typically aren’t that effective in the water. So, needless to say, I’ve never been white water rafting. One of the things that keeps me off the rapids is the high current of the water. A friend once told me that he got knocked out of a raft, went underwater, and was immediately shot several rafts away from the one he started in. A group of strangers had to pull him into their raft, because there was no hope of him getting back to his. Another buddy told me how he once fell out and got sucked *underneath* his own raft. He had to push off the bottom of his own boat in order to get free and, when he did, the current sent him downstream like a missile. Sorry, but that’s just not my idea of fun. This body belongs on dry land or at least in a sturdy boat with an engine—preferably a cruise ship.

I don’t like being at the mercy of a current I can’t control. On one hand, it’s easy. The current does all the work. On the other hand, you don’t get to choose your destination. If you stay in your raft, the river will take you where it wants you to go. And, at the end of the ride, you’ll find yourself surrounded by everyone else who took the same trip you did. That’s how I view the myths society tells us about building wealth. The culture is flowing one way, pushing us along with lies about debt, credit cards, student loans, home equity lines of credit, and overspending. It’s easy to buy into the fear, myths, and lies we hear every day, because going with the flow and believing what everyone else believes doesn’t require anything of us. We can just hang on, take the same ride as everyone else, and get the same rewards. When it comes to building wealth, though, the ones who come out on top aren’t the ones who merely *survive* the ride; it’s the ones